

# SWITZERLAND — Business Formation Guide

**RKPT TECH LTD | Swiss Business Hub** *Verified against official government sources — September 2026*

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## 1. Snapshot

|                                       |                                                |
|---------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| Recommended structure                 | GmbH / Sàrl / Sagl (alternative: AG / SA)      |
| Authority                             | Cantonal Commercial Register (Handelsregister) |
| Minimum capital                       | CHF 20,000 (GmbH), fully paid in               |
| Government/third-party formation cost | ~CHF 1,300–4,600+ (excludes capital)           |
| Typical registration time             | 2–4 weeks                                      |
| Critical requirement                  | Swiss-resident authorised representative       |

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## 2. Recommended Structure

**GmbH / Sàrl / Sagl** is Switzerland's standard limited-liability company for SMEs and owner-run businesses — minimum capital **CHF 20,000**, fully paid.

**AG / SA** (public limited company) is the alternative — minimum capital **CHF 100,000**, of which at least **CHF 50,000** must be paid in at formation. AG suits businesses prioritising privacy or investor structures; GmbH suits budget-driven founders. Conversion between the two is possible later.

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## 3. Company Formation — Step by Step

1. **Select canton and municipality** — this affects tax rates, administration and cost
2. **Choose company name** — must comply with Swiss naming rules and include the required legal suffix (GmbH/Sàrl or AG/SA)

3. **Identify shareholders** and capital contributions
  4. **Define business purpose**
  5. **Deposit the required share capital** into a blocked Swiss capital account (CHF 20,000 for GmbH; at least CHF 50,000 of CHF 100,000 for AG)
  6. **Prepare the articles of association**
  7. **Complete public notarisation** of the founding deed
  8. **Arrange Swiss-resident representation** — at least one person authorised to represent the company must be resident in Switzerland
  9. **Submit to the competent cantonal Commercial Register** — the company legally comes into existence on registration
  10. **Complete beneficial-ownership notification** where participation reaches or exceeds 25%
  11. **Register for tax** (federal, cantonal, municipal, VAT where applicable)
  12. **Open the operational business bank account**
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## 4. Documents & Information Required

- Passport/ID of all shareholders and managers
  - Evidence of the Swiss-resident authorised representative
  - Articles of association
  - Notarised founding deed
  - Capital payment confirmation from the blocked account bank
  - Registered office/domicile address in the chosen canton
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## 5. Costs (Government fees — separated from other costs)

| Item                    | Cost                                                                    |
|-------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Commercial Register fee | ~CHF 600 (federal base harmonised; some cantonal variance, CHF 400–800) |
|                         |                                                                         |

|                                               |                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Notary fee                                    | CHF 500–2,000+ (canton-dependent — Zug/Schwyz lower, Zurich/Geneva higher)       |
| Formation/advisory fee                        | CHF 600–2,000 (some providers offer fixed-fee packages from ~CHF 490–750 all-in) |
| Capital deposit/blocked account fee           | CHF 150–500                                                                      |
| <b>Total third-party cost (excl. capital)</b> | <b>~CHF 1,300–4,600+</b>                                                         |

**Share capital: CHF 20,000 (GmbH) or CHF 100,000 (AG)** — this is company equity, not a government fee. It becomes the company's working capital after registration.

Federal issuance stamp tax of 1% only applies to equity above CHF 1,000,000 — irrelevant for a standard GmbH/AG formation.

## 6. Timeframe

| Stage                                           | Indicative time                                                                             |
|-------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Document preparation                            | 1–2 weeks                                                                                   |
| Notarial process                                | Dependent on notary availability                                                            |
| Commercial Register entry                       | ~5–10 working days once filing is complete (up to 5–60 days in complex/high-workload cases) |
| Banking (capital account + operational account) | Often the slowest step — 1–4+ weeks, longer for non-resident founders                       |
| Full operational setup                          | 2–4 weeks typical; up to 6+ weeks in complex cases                                          |

## 7. Tax & Ongoing Compliance

| Item                                        | Rate                              |
|---------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| Federal corporate tax                       | 8.5%                              |
| Combined effective corporate tax (federal + | 11.66%–20.54% depending on canton |

|                               |                                |
|-------------------------------|--------------------------------|
| cantonal + municipal)         | (national average ~14.4%)      |
| VAT — standard rate           | 8.1%                           |
| VAT registration threshold    | CHF 100,000                    |
| Beneficial-owner notification | Required at ≥25% participation |

**Ongoing obligations:** accounting and financial reporting under the Code of Obligations, federal/cantonal/municipal tax filings, VAT returns where registered, payroll and social-security contributions, Commercial Register updates.

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## 8. Important Information

- **The Swiss-resident representative requirement is the critical point for foreign founders.** At least one person authorised to represent the company must be resident in Switzerland with the right to work/reside there — this can be a manager, director, or authorised representative arranged as a service.
- **Canton choice materially affects tax.** Effective combined corporate tax rates vary from roughly 11.7% (Zug/Lucerne) to over 20% (Zurich, Bern) — the canton is a real strategic decision, not just an address.
- **Immigration is strictly quota-based and separate from incorporation.** Non-EU/EFTA nationals require an employer-sponsored work permit; the employer must demonstrate no suitable Swiss or EU/EFTA candidate was available. The national quota for 2026 is **8,500 permits** (4,500 B + 4,000 L), with a separate UK-specific quota of **3,500** (2,100 B + 1,400 L). There is no dedicated Swiss start-up visa — self-employment is possible but requires separate cantonal approval, and the process is slow (months, not weeks).
- Company formation does **not** automatically grant work or residence rights.

**Disclaimer:** Fees, thresholds and requirements change and should be reconfirmed at [zefix.ch](https://www.zefix.ch) or [estv.admin.ch](https://www.estv.admin.ch) before reliance. This is general information, not legal, tax or immigration advice.

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## 9. Official Sources (checked September 2026)

- Zefix — federal commercial registry index — <https://www.zefix.ch>
- Federal Tax Administration (FTA/ESTV) — <https://www.estv.admin.ch>

- State Secretariat for Migration (SEM) — <https://www.sem.admin.ch>
- Swiss SME Portal — <https://www.kmu.admin.ch>